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The Linguini business model

Free for a daily photo, Plus when one a day isn't enough. How we priced Linguini around learners, competitors and the AI cost of every lesson.

● Proposed pricing, not live yet · prices checked 23–24 September 2026

Free gives every learner **one photo lesson and one journal page a day**. Plus is **\$49.99 a year** for anyone who wants more. Each photo lesson costs us about **2¢ in AI**, so the free tier pays for itself once enough people upgrade: **3.8% of learners** from 2027, or about 1% once we move to cheaper models.

The model at a glance

The free plan limits the one thing that costs us money: AI reading your own photos. The learning stays free.

■ How we deliver ■ What learners get ■ Who we serve ■ Money

VALUE PROPOSITION

Learn the language of your own day.

-  Your photo is the lesson
-  Hear it, say it, play it
-  Keep the day as a journal page

CUSTOMER SEGMENTS



Returning learners



Everyday beginners



Students and travellers

RELATIONSHIPS



Daily streak



Journal habit



Founding Plus club

CHANNELS



Landing demo



Product Hunt



Reddit - Discord



Share cards

KEY ACTIVITIES



Photo → lesson



Curate scenes



Keep AI cost low

KEY PARTNERS



Google Gemini



OpenAI



Supabase



Vercel - Render



Stripe



Tutors and creators

KEY RESOURCES



Lesson pipeline



Scene library



Vocabulary data

COST STRUCTURE

1.9¢

AI per photo lesson (2027)

\$52–70

hosting a month

3.4% + 50¢

per card payment

REVENUE STREAMS

\$49.99

Plus a year, or \$7.99/mo

\$34.99

Founding Plus, first 300

Later

family, classroom, print

Linguini's business model canvas. The customer segments are example learner types, not real users.

Plans

	Free \$0 forever	Plus \$49.99 a year · or \$7.99/mo	Founding \$34.99 a year · first 300
Photo lessons	1 /day	10 /day	10 /day
Photos per journal page	1	10	10
Curated scenes	∞	∞	∞
Pronunciation feedback	—	✓	✓
Review mode	—	✓	✓
Competitive I-Spy beta	—	—	✓
Vote on the roadmap	—	—	✓

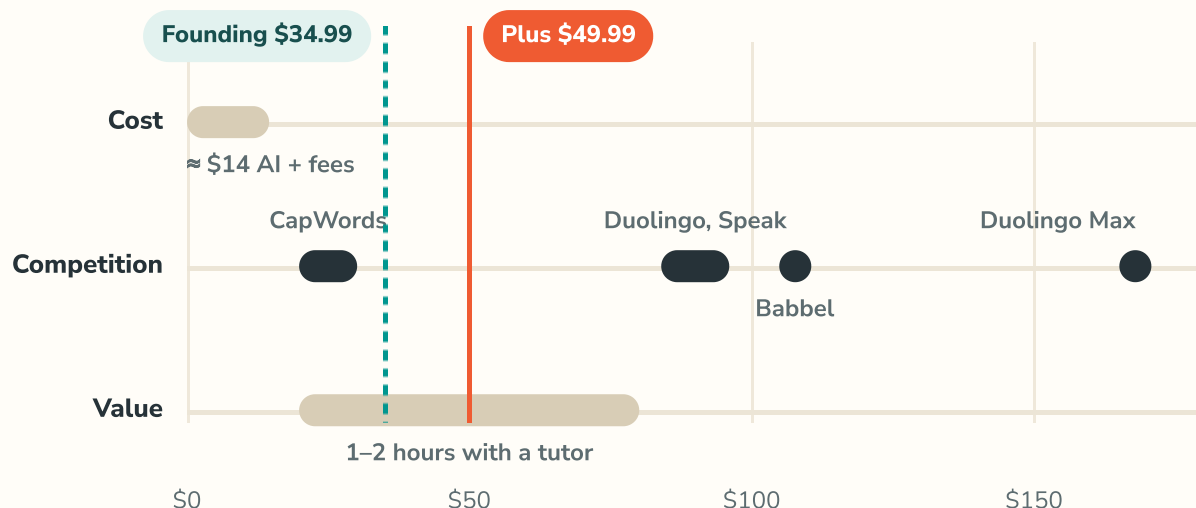
Beginners and returning learners need a small daily habit, not a heavy course, so one free photo lesson a day is the habit. Curated scenes are analysed once in advance, so free learners can replay them all day for almost nothing. You upgrade when you took more photos today than one lesson covers.

How we set the price

We checked \$49.99 three ways: what it costs us, what other apps charge, and what a tutor costs.

What a year of Linguini should cost

Annual prices, US dollars



Cost sets the floor.

A typical Plus learner costs us about \$14 a year in AI, storage and card fees. Anything above that can also carry some free learners.

Competitors set the range.

Photo-flashcard apps charge \$20–30 a year. Duolingo, Speak and Babel charge \$84–168. We do more than a flashcard app and less than a full course.

Value sets the ceiling.

An online tutor costs \$15–60 an hour. A year of daily practice should cost less than one or two lessons.

So Plus is \$49.99 a year.

That is close to the \$44.99 education-app median and below every course app. Our first 300 members lock in \$34.99.

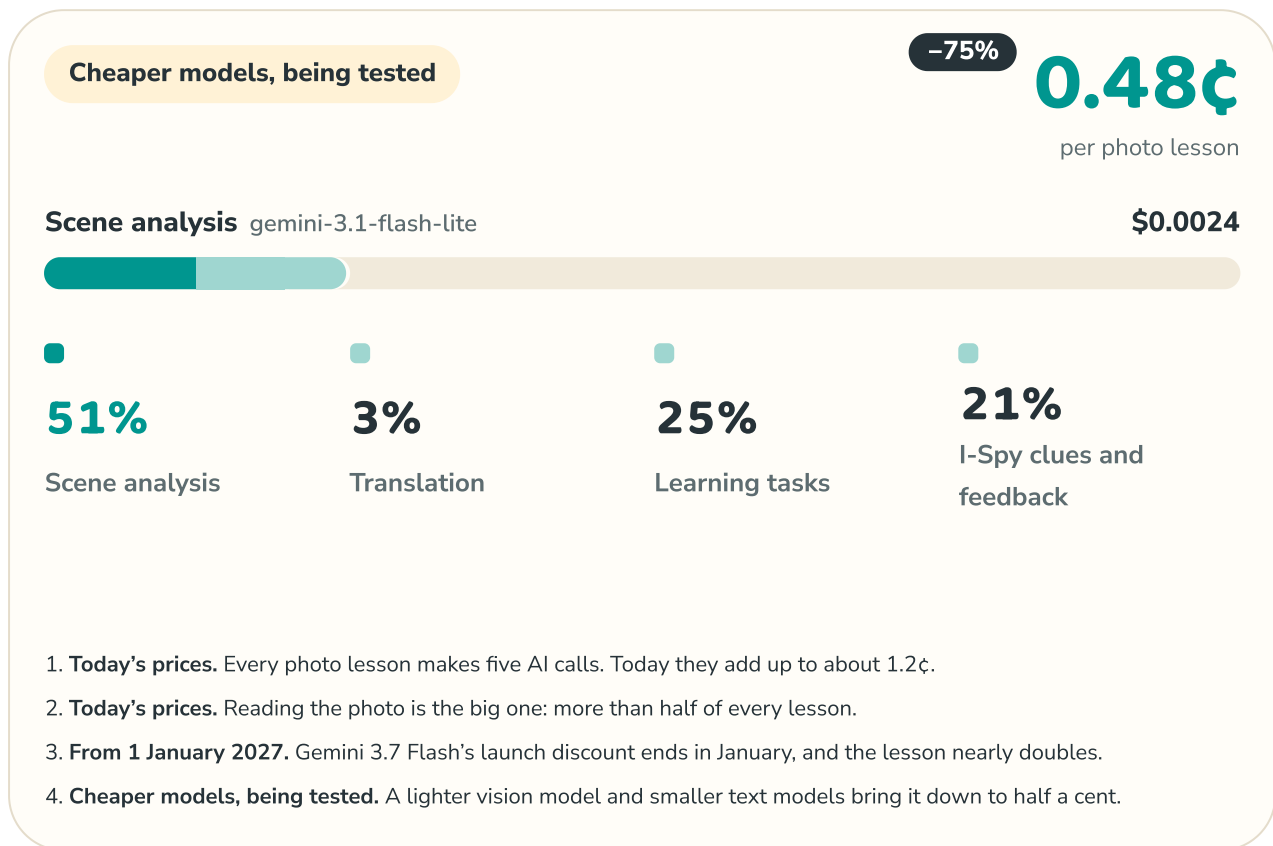
Against the competition

App	Price a year	Own photos	Journal
Linguini Plus Free: 1 photo lesson a day	\$49.99	☒	☒
CapWords Premium Free: A few captures	\$19.99–29.99	☒	☐
Speak Premium Free: Short taster	\$83.99	☐	☐
Duolingo Super Free: About 2–3 lessons a day	\$84–96	☐	☐
Babel 12 months Free: Short taster	\$107.64	☐	☐

US list prices checked September 2026; they vary by country and promotion. CapWords turns photos into flashcards, without games or a journal.

From Duolingo we took the shape of the free tier: keep it genuinely useful, limit how much you can do, and save the expensive AI for paid plans.

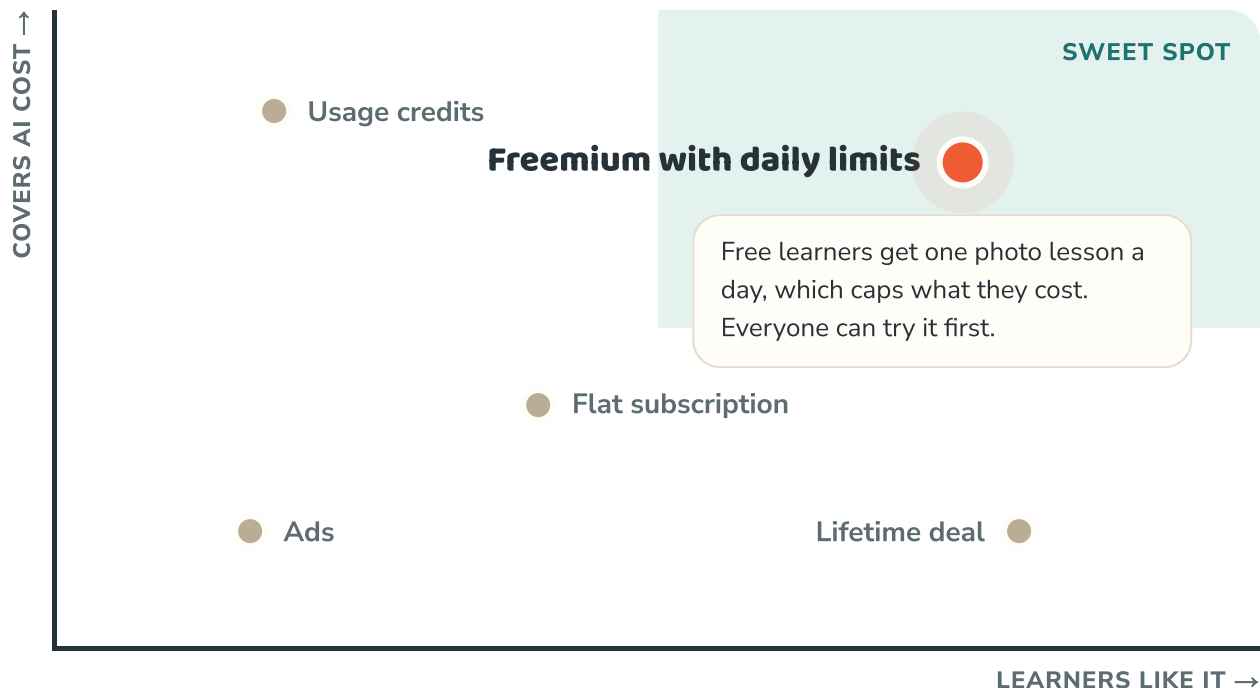
What a lesson costs us



On top of that, hosting is a fixed \$52–70 a month (Vercel, Supabase and Render). Stripe keeps 3.4% + 50¢ of each payment, which is why we push the annual plan. After fees, a Plus learner brings in about \$5.24 a month.

Why freemium

AI costs grow with every lesson, so each pricing model has to answer two questions.



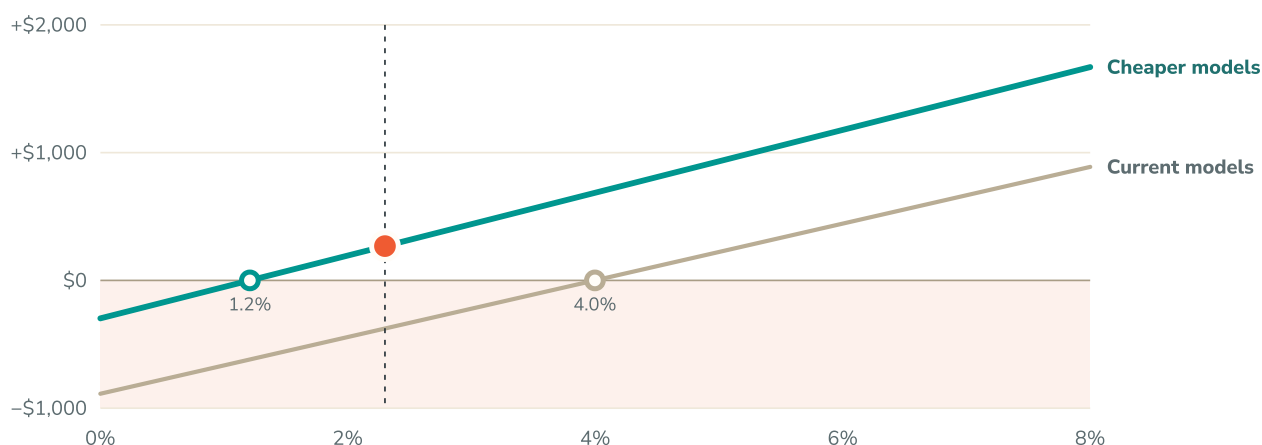
Hover or tap a model to see why we passed on it.

Does the free tier pay for itself?

Every payer also carries the free learners: about 42 of them when 2.3% pay. On our current models at 2027 prices that only pays off once about 4% of learners pay. The cheaper models break even at about 1%, so that is the pipeline we launch on. Drag the sliders to try other numbers.

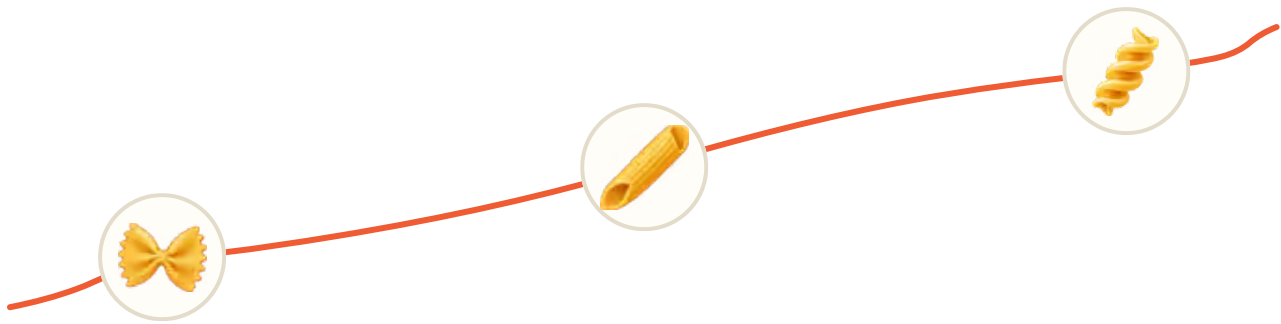
With **5,000** learners and **2.3%** paying, Linguini makes **+\$268** a month on the cheaper models.

On our current models, at 2027 prices, it would be **-\$377**.



Before a wide launch we will test cheaper vision models on 50 labelled photos, enforce the daily limits on the server, and track what every lesson costs.

What success looks like, stage by stage



NOW · BETA

Proof it sticks

A second lesson within a week

Earning nothing yet

LAUNCH YEAR

Proof people pay

300 Founding Plus members

Plus and Founding Plus

AFTER THAT

Proof it scales

4% of learners paying

Adds family, classroom and print

Founding Plus

- \$34.99 a year, locked for as long as you stay, for the first 300 members.
- First into competitive I-Spy, a monthly roadmap vote and a call with the makers.
- Paying buys early access and a say, never an advantage in ranked play.

Sources

[Gemini API pricing](#) · [OpenAI API pricing](#) · [Supabase](#) · [Vercel](#) · [Stripe](#) · [Duolingo Q2 2026 letter](#) · [Duolingo prices](#) · [Babbel prices](#) · [Speak prices](#) · [CapWords](#) · [RevenueCat SOSA 2026](#) · [italki tutor costs](#). Token counts are estimates from our prompts and output limits.